Alexander Bakin

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DevOps Engineer | AWS, Kubernetes, CI/CD, GitOps

Summary

DevOps Engineer with 5+ years in operations, on AWS and Kubernetes since 2023, most recently on a 4-person platform team serving 65 engineers, 43 microservices and 12k RPS at peak. Owned the GitLab CI templates behind CI/CD standardisation across those services and built canary releases on Argo Rollouts while production deploys grew 29 → 83 a week at a 6% change failure rate. Led the engineering side of a 33% AWS cost reduction and commanded incidents on a 1-in-4 on-call rotation. AWS Certified Solutions Architect – Associate.

Work Experience

DevOps Engineer Nov 2023 — Aug 2026
ELEKS *Remote (Kraków, Poland)*

Moved from L3 into an e-commerce marketplace client's platform team (team lead, SRE, platform engineer), focused on delivery speed and release reliability. All four rotated on-call and operations, often sharing SRE and platform tasks.

Delivery and release reliability

- Owned the GitLab CI templates for CI/CD standardisation across 43 microservices, with versioning and override rules
- Co-developed the Helm library chart and Argo CD flow with the platform engineer
- Ran the team-by-team migration with guides and pairing sessions, all 8 teams in 9 months
- Proposed and delivered faster MR pipelines with BuildKit caching, CodeArtifact, an ECR pull-through cache and spot runners, while service teams parallelised their tests: median 22 → 10 min
- Built canary releases for 19 user-facing services on Argo Rollouts, auto-aborted by SRE-designed analysis
- Built DORA tracking in Grafana: production deploys 29 → 83 a week at a 6% change failure rate (aborted canaries included); release-caused incidents 7 → 3 per quarter

Platform and self-service

- Proposed and built KEDA autoscaling on Kafka lag (MSK, 40k msg/s peak) with service teams
- Automated self-service setup for new services (namespaces, IAM, RDS, S3) on the platform engineer's infrastructure with Terraform, GitLab CI and ApplicationSets: 2 days of tickets → ~20 min
- Automated ephemeral environments per MR with Argo CD, each with its own schema or database on shared backing services, removing a 1-day wait for staging
- Wrote parts of the shared Terraform module library, added scheduled drift detection and security's Checkov checks, and proposed changes to developer-owned stacks as MRs for their teams to approve
- Ran 3 of 7 EKS upgrades (1.28 → 1.35) from the team lead's plans and debugged cluster networking in incidents (VPC peering, Transit Gateway)

Reliability and incident response

- Ran the observability stack (Prometheus, Grafana, Loki, Alertmanager) on rotation and helped move metrics to VictoriaMetrics for 90-day retention
- Ran backup and recovery for production RDS PostgreSQL on rotation, restore-tested to the client's RPO/RTO, with cross-region, cross-account AWS Backup copies (security's Vault Lock) and second-region read replicas
- Tested a full in-region rebuild of the 3-AZ cluster (Terraform, Argo CD, Velero) in under an hour
- Commanded incidents and facilitated about 8 blameless postmortems a year, tracking team-owned actions to closure
- Helped the SRE set up SLOs, burn-rate paging and runbooks, ticketing no-user-impact alerts: pages ~30 → 9 a week

Security and cost

- Helped teams move secrets for 43 services to Secrets Manager with External Secrets Operator and RDS rotation
- Added security's SonarQube, Trivy and Gitleaks gates, enforced at deploy via Cosign and Kyverno verifyImages, with emergency overrides as expiring single-image PolicyExceptions approved by security and the incident commander
- Took Kyverno to enforce with the platform engineer and security, exempting rootless BuildKit on tainted runner nodes
- Led the engineering side of the cost programme with Cost Explorer and Infracost: AWS spend $89k → $60k/mo (−33%)
- Compute: owner-approved VPA rightsizing and Karpenter spot for stateless services (55% of EKS compute) with graceful shutdown and PodDisruptionBudgets, plus a Compute Savings Plan sized to the rest for finance to buy
- Data and network: owner-approved RDS rightsizing, gp3 and RIs (bought by finance), Graviton MSK with tiered storage, and VPC endpoints (with the platform engineer) and topology-aware routing to cut NAT and cross-AZ traffic

L3 Support Specialist Apr 2022 — Nov 2023
ELEKS *Remote (Kraków, Poland)*

L3 team for a Web Application Firewall (WAF) platform giving cloud provider clients DDoS and L7 attack mitigation: 5–10k RPS normal traffic across all clients and 10k+ RPS filtered per client during DDoS.

- Automated deployment of WAF components (nginx and modules) using Ansible and GitLab CI: deployment time 5 hours → 38 min
- Wrote custom Prometheus exporters in Go, Python and Bash for the WAF platform (nginx, modules, servers), feeding Grafana dashboards and alert rules
- Ran 22 dedicated Linux servers and 13 VMs for the highly available platform meeting a 99.9% uptime SLA, including self-hosted PostgreSQL and RabbitMQ (replication, backups and restores, upgrades)
- Tuned nginx and Linux for attack traffic (rate limits, mitigation rules, sysctl and conntrack limits) and debugged it with tcpdump and strace
- Resolved 100+ incidents on PagerDuty on-call, 97% within SLA, including hands-on DDoS mitigation, and wrote a dozen RCA and postmortem reports with tracked actions
- Mentored two L2 engineers through shadowing on live incidents until they handled those incident types themselves, and wrote Confluence knowledge base articles

System Administrator Jan 2021 — Feb 2022
Siemens *Remote (Tbilisi, Georgia)*

- Managed 11 Linux servers on VMware ESXi hosting internal developer tooling, maintaining the Ansible playbooks for installation, configuration and updates
- Managed 214 Linux workstations with the existing Puppet setup to deploy updates and application configurations

Skills

- **AWS:** EKS (Pod Identity), EC2, VPC, ALB, ECR, RDS (Multi-AZ), MSK, S3, IAM (Least Privilege), Organizations, Secrets Manager (Rotation), CloudWatch, Route 53, CloudFront, ACM, AWS Backup
- **Kubernetes & Containers:** Kubernetes (EKS, RBAC, HPA, VPA, PodDisruptionBudgets), Docker, Helm (Library Charts), Karpenter, KEDA, Velero, AWS Load Balancer Controller, External Secrets Operator
- **Infrastructure as Code (IaC) & Automation:** Terraform (Shared Modules), Ansible, Puppet
- **CI/CD & GitOps:** GitLab CI (Shared Templates, Runners on Kubernetes), GitHub Actions (Personal Projects, OIDC to AWS), Argo CD (Applications, ApplicationSets), Argo Rollouts (Canary Analysis), BuildKit, CodeArtifact
- **Observability & Monitoring:** Prometheus, VictoriaMetrics, Grafana, Loki, Alertmanager, SLOs, Burn-rate Alerts
- **Security:** Trivy, Gitleaks, Checkov, SonarQube, Cosign, Kyverno (Policy as Code), DevSecOps
- **Data & Messaging:** PostgreSQL (RDS and Self-hosted), Kafka (MSK), RabbitMQ (Self-hosted)
- **Reliability & Cost:** Incident Response, On-call (PagerDuty), Blameless Postmortems, DORA Metrics, Disaster Recovery, FinOps, Infracost, Cost Explorer, Savings Plans
- **Programming:** Go, Python, Bash (Custom Prometheus Exporters)
- **Linux & Tools:** Linux, Networking (TCP/IP, DNS, Load Balancing), nginx, Git, VMware ESXi

Education & Certifications

Higher School of Economics Moscow, Russia
Bachelor's Degree, Computer Science *Sep 2020 — Jul 2024*

AWS Certified Solutions Architect – Associate, Amazon Web Services Issued Aug 2026

Projects

Personal Blog on Serverless AWS Infrastructure (alexanderbakin.com) Jan 2020 — Present

- Moved the blog to AWS in 2023 and recently reworked it for lower cost: Hugo served via S3 (private, encrypted) behind CloudFront with Origin Access Control, Route 53 for DNS, and ACM for TLS
- Built two independent GitHub Actions pipelines (infrastructure via Terraform, content via S3 sync) with OIDC-based auth, eliminating long-lived AWS credentials; runs for ~$0.63/mo